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Want to go apple-picking? Across northern Illinois, farmers are scrambling, and some orchards might not even open after several spring frosts killed crops



SHAKEN TO THE CORE

By Adriana Pérez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In almost three decades of growing apples at her family’s orchard in northern Illinois, SueEllen Arndt and her husband, Ralph, never experienced anything like this year.

Five spring frosts killed most of the blooms on their trees, she said, forcing Prairie Sky Orchard to close for the 2026 fall harvest season.

“In the last few years, they’ve been blooming ahead of schedule because we’re getting warmer weather earlier, and it’s just cyclic,” Arndt said. “We’ve had some frosts in the past that have affected some of our blossoms, but we’ve never had it where we’ve had five frosts that have — it is hard to find an apple out there.”



Ralph and SueEllen Arndt, top, stand by one of the few honeycrisp apples on their trees on Thursday at Prairie Sky Orchard in Union after five frosts killed 99% of their blooms this year. They’ve added a sign at their front gate, above, to turn away visitors. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Located in the village of Union in McHenry County, some 60 miles northwest of downtown Chicago, Prairie Sky has 2,500 dwarf trees that grow 15 apple varieties, as well as pears.

Climate change is consistently warming winter temperatures across northern Illinois, signaling earlier spring arrivals to plants, said Trent Ford, the state climatologist. At the same time, while final spring freezes are happening earlier in the Midwest, that trend is much more variable and hard to predict. A study he co-authored last year found full bloom dates for apples are expected to shift one to two weeks earlier in the spring across different Midwest climates by mid-century because of warmer winter and spring air

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“Some of the safety nets that are there for commodity crops (are) not as well developed for specialty crops. When we have big losses related to weather for corn and soybeans, a lot of times folks will have crop insurance. We don’t necessarily have all the same options for specialty crops. ... A lot of times, it’s just a complete loss.”

TRENT FORD, the state climatologist

Tehran digs in as war lingers

Iran confident in its push to prolong fight, report finds

By Julian E. Barnes
and Dustin Volz
THE NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — Iran has grown more confident in its ability to attack targets in the Middle East and appears determined to continue the conflict for months to frustrate the United States, according to U.S. intelligence reports in recent weeks.

In many respects, the assessments reflect what has been observable on the ground as fighting erupted again after a period of relative calm. In the past week, Iran targeted ships in the Strait of Hormuz and U.S. troops in the region, and U.S. forces struck inside Iran, killing military personnel and civilians.

The new exchanges have been limited. But the intelligence reports, according to people who have read them, suggest that Iran’s hard-line government might be contemplating a significant escalation.

Iran has emerged from months of the on-again, off-again war with a far better understanding of its military strengths and is more sure of its capabilities, according to officials briefed on the intelligence.

The reports, some current and former officials said, suggest that any agreement to fully end the war will be hard to reach.

There are few signs that Iran is ready to make any sort of deal with the United States, content to exacerbate President Donald Trump’s political problems ahead of the U.S. midterm elections, according to some officials.

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SPORTS

Teel back for playoff push

Catcher Kyle Teel, who has missed most of the 2026 campaign due to various injuries, was back in the White Sox lineup Friday, hoping to provide a boost for Chicago down the stretch as it clings to a slim lead over the Guardians in the AL Central race.

After ‘42 very difficult days’ in ICE detention, home at last

Chicago Public Schools custodian was detained during asylum appointment

By Allison Kiehl
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

After more than a month away from home in Immigration and Customs Enforcement detention, a Farnsworth Elementary School custodian was reunited with his family on Aug. 28, family members confirmed.

Josue Pire Hidalgo was detained on the morning of July 17 during what his family believed would be a routine ICE appointment for their

asylum case, an appointment they had waited more than three years to attend. They entered the United States in late 2022, applied for asylum, obtained work permits and secured jobs as Chicago Public Schools custodians.

“It was a terrible day,” Pire Hidalgo said in Spanish. “We did not believe that I would be arrested because we are not criminals; we try to be exemplary citizens. We have been law-abiding. It was difficult in that moment because I felt

like I had been treated like a criminal, though I am not.”

Pire Hidalgo was processed through the ICE facility in west suburban Broadview before being transferred to the Clay County Jail in Brazil, Indiana, about 200 miles south of downtown Chicago. He was incarcerated for six weeks.

“It was 42 very difficult days for our family; stressful, desperate and very costly, but always trusting in God and in his lawyer, Carla Espinoza,” his wife, Yulexis Padilla, said in Spanish.

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Josue Pire Hidalgo, center, relaxes with his children Sebastian and Madison at home in Chicago’s Lincoln Square on Friday. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



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